

The Plumbing Leak Decision Guide: Know When to Fix It Yourself and When to Call a Pro

Introduction

You're looking at a wet spot under your sink. It's small. Maybe it'll dry out on its own.

You're not a handy person. You know enough to be dangerous — you could probably tighten a fitting or patch a small leak with tape you saw on YouTube. But you also know that plumbing problems can escalate fast, and you've heard the horror stories: a small leak that turned into a \$15,000 water damage claim, or a DIY patch that held for two weeks and then burst at 2am.

So you're stuck. Do you tinker and hope for the best? Or do you call a plumber, pay \$150 just to show up, and potentially get a quote that feels overpriced for what looks like a minor problem?

Here's what you need: a way to actually assess what you're dealing with before you commit to a call or a repair. Not a tutorial on fixing pipes — a decision framework that tells you: what kind of leak you have, how urgent it is, what you can safely attempt yourself, and what signals mean "stop and call a pro now."

This guide gives you that. You'll learn to read the leak, understand the risk profile, and make a confident call — whether that ends up being a DIY fix or a professional one.

Part 1: The Assessment

Learn to identify what you're actually dealing with

Chapter 1: Read the Leak — A Classification System

Before you can decide what to do, you need to name what you're seeing. Plumbing leaks fall into five categories, and each one has a different urgency level and repair path.

Category 1: Slow Seep

Water is slowly leaking at a joint or connection. You'll see dampness, not active dripping. The pipe may have a worn washer, a loose fitting, or minor corrosion.

Urgency: Low to medium. This can wait a few days to a week if you monitor it.

DIY potential: High, if the connection is accessible.

Category 2: Active Drip

Continuous dripping from a visible point — usually a faucet, a showerhead, or a pipe joint. The drip rate may be slow but consistent.

Urgency: Medium. An active drip will get worse over time as corrosion progresses or washers deteriorate.

DIY potential: Moderate. If the dripping point is accessible and you can identify the faulty component (washer, cartridge, O-ring), you can fix it. If not, call a pro.

Category 3: Pressure Leak

Water is spraying or streaming from a pipe under pressure. This is not a drip — it's a flow. You can often hear it before you see it.

Urgency: High. Shut off your water immediately at the main shut-off valve. Do not attempt to repair this yourself. The pressure can cause serious injury and the water volume can cause rapid damage.

DIY potential: None. Call a plumber.

Category 4: Hidden Leak

Water is leaking somewhere you can't see — inside a wall, under a floor, in a ceiling cavity. You won't see the water; you'll see the evidence: musty odors, discoloration or bubbling paint, soft spots in drywall, warped baseboards, or an unexplained spike in your water bill.

Urgency: Medium to high, depending on duration. Hidden leaks cause structural damage and mold. The longer you wait, the worse it gets.

DIY potential: None for the repair itself. But you may be able to contain the symptom temporarily while you arrange professional detection and repair.

Category 5: Slab Leak

A leak in pipes running under your home's concrete foundation. Signs include: a warm spot on the floor (hot water line), the sound of water running under the slab when

nothing is on, cracks in the foundation or tile, or moisture seeping up around the edges of rooms.

Urgency: High. Slab leaks require professional rerouting or jackhammering. Cost: \$500 to \$3,000+, depending on accessibility and whether repiping is needed.

DIY potential: None.

The Leak Quick-Reference

Type	What It Looks Like	Urgency	DIY?
Slow seep	Damp spot, no active drip	Low-Medium	Yes, if accessible
Active drip	Continuous dripping	Medium	Maybe — depends on access
Pressure leak	Spraying or streaming water	High	No — call pro now
Hidden leak	Musty smell, stains, high water bill	Medium-High	No — call pro
Slab leak	Warm floor, running water sound under slab	High	No — call pro

Chapter 2: The Shut-Off Protocol

Every homeowner should know where their water shut-off valves are and how to use them. This isn't optional. If you have a pressure leak and you don't know how to shut off your main water, you're looking at serious damage in minutes.

Finding Your Main Shut-Off

The main shut-off valve is typically located where your water service line enters the house:

- Near the water meter (often in a box buried near the street or sidewalk)
- In the basement or utility room where the main line comes through the wall
- In a mechanical room or crawl space
- For homes on wells, near the pressure tank

If you share a wall with a neighbor (townhouse or condo), check both sides of that wall — the valve might be on either side.

How to Shut Off

There are two types of valves:

- **Gate valve:** Has a round wheel. Turn clockwise to close. If it's stiff or makes a grinding sound, work it slowly — forcing it can break it.
- **Ball valve:** Has a lever handle. Turn the lever 90 degrees (quarter-turn) to close. When the lever is perpendicular to the pipe, it's off.

Test your main shut-off once a year: turn it off and back on. If it's stiff or doesn't fully close, have it serviced before you need it in an emergency.

Individual Shut-Off Valves

Every fixture in your home should have its own shut-off valve. Look under sinks and behind toilets — there will be small valves on the supply lines. These let you isolate one fixture without shutting off water to the entire house.

Learn where these are. When you have an active drip under a sink, you can shut off that one valve, clear the cabinet, and work without water to the rest of the house.

The "Running Water" Rule

If you can hear water running and you know nothing in your house is using water, shut off your main immediately. You have a leak somewhere, and it's likely a pressure leak or a break in the main line. The sound of running water when everything is off is a red-alert signal.

Action Step: This week, locate your main shut-off valve. Practice turning it off and on. Check that it fully closes. Note any stiffness or grinding. If it doesn't work properly, call a plumber to service or replace it now — before you need it in an emergency.

Chapter 3: The Leak Severity Calculator

Use this 7-point rubric to calculate the severity of your leak. Rate yourself on each point, then see the action recommendation at the end.

Point 1: Location

- Exposed pipe (visible under sink, in basement): Score 1
- Partially concealed (behind a panel, under a vanity): Score 2
- Fully hidden (inside wall, under slab): Score 4

Point 2: Flow Rate

- Damp or wet only when the system is in use: Score 1
- Intermittent drip: Score 2
- Continuous drip or slow stream: Score 3
- Active pressure stream or spray: Score 5

Point 3: Duration

- Just discovered (today): Score 1
- A few days to a week: Score 2
- Weeks: Score 3
- Months: Score 5

Point 4: Progression

- No change from initial state: Score 1
- Slightly worse over time: Score 2
- Noticeably worse week over week: Score 4

Point 5: Access

- Can reach the pipe with basic tools: Score 1
- Can reach but it requires removing a panel or vanity: Score 2
- Cannot access without wall demolition or floor removal: Score 4

Point 6: Pressure

- Not under main pressure (drainage or low-use line): Score 1
- Connected to main pressure but isolated valve available: Score 3
- Main pressure line, cannot isolate: Score 5

Point 7: Evidence of Damage

- No visible damage to surrounding structure: Score 1
 - Minor surface damage (water stains, slight softening): Score 3
 - Significant structural damage (soft drywall, mold smell, warped flooring): Score 5
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Calculate Your Total

Add your scores across all 7 points.

0-12: Green Zone — DIY Viable Your leak is low-urgency, accessible, and manageable with basic tools and parts. You can fix it yourself or schedule a plumber within the next week without major risk.

13-24: Yellow Zone — Schedule a Pro Your leak has elevated urgency or accessibility challenges. Schedule a plumber within 48-72 hours. In the meantime, monitor closely and be prepared to shut off water if it worsens.

25+: Red Zone — Call a Pro Now Your leak has high damage potential or involves pressure lines, hidden spaces, or structural damage. Call a plumber today. Do not attempt to repair — contain what you can and wait for professional help.

Action Step: Evaluate your current leak using this rubric. Write down your score for each point. Calculate your total and follow the action recommendation. If you're in the Red Zone and you haven't already shut off your water, do that first — then call.

Part 2: DIY or Don't

The decision framework

Chapter 4: What You Can Actually Fix

This is the honest list of what a non-plumber can handle safely. No soldering, no torch work, no specialized equipment. If you can get to the leak and you can identify the part, you can probably fix it.

What Falls in the DIY Range

- **Faucet washer replacement:** The most common source of drips. A \$5 washer and a wrench. Turn off the supply valves under the sink, remove the handle, pull

out the old washer, press in the new one, reassemble. Most hardware stores carry a washer kit with multiple sizes.

- **Supply line replacement:** If a braided stainless steel supply line (the hose connecting your pipe to the fixture) is leaking at either end, replace it. They cost \$10-\$20 and take 10 minutes. Unplug the old line, screw on the new one, hand-tighten, then a quarter-turn with a wrench. Don't over-tighten.
- **P-trap leak at joint:** The P-trap is the curved pipe under your sink. If it's leaking at a threaded connection, you can disconnect it, clean the threads, apply new plumber's tape (three wraps, clockwise), and reassemble. Use two wrenches — one to hold the fitting, one to tighten.
- **Toilet flapper replacement:** The rubber flapper inside your toilet tank is the most common source of a running toilet. It costs \$5 and takes 10 minutes. Turn off the water at the supply valve, flush to drain the tank, unhook the old flapper from the overflow tube and the chain, hook in the new one, adjust chain length so there's a little slack, turn water back on.
- **Showerhead replacement:** If your showerhead is leaking at the connection, you can remove it with a wrench (protect the finish with a rag), clean the threads, apply new plumber's tape, and screw on a new showerhead. Replacement heads start at \$10.
- **Faucet cartridge replacement:** For single-handle faucets with a persistent drip (not a washer issue), the cartridge inside the faucet may be worn. Cartridge kits are \$15-\$30 and come with instructions. The job requires removing the handle and pulling out the old cartridge; it's more involved than a washer job but still in DIY range if you're comfortable with a few more steps.

What's NOT in the DIY Range

- Anything requiring soldering or a torch
- Main water line breaks or pressure leaks
- Leaks inside walls or under slabs
- Gas line work (even small gas plumbing is not DIY — gas leaks are life-threatening)
- Sewer line issues
- Water heater problems beyond basic valve adjustments
- Any work that requires cutting into concrete or drywall

The Stop Point

Here's the rule: if you're more than 30 minutes into a repair and it's not working, stop. Call a pro. The "I can figure this out" spiral is how small leaks become big bills. A plumber's service call is \$85-\$150. A botched DIY that creates additional damage can be \$500+.

Chapter 5: The Cost Estimation Tool

One of the most common homeowner mistakes is calling a plumber without enough information to evaluate the quote. Here's how to go in informed.

Plumber Pricing Basics (2025-2026)

- Hourly rates: \$85-\$150 per hour, depending on region and plumber experience. Always ask: "Is this a flat rate or hourly?" If they're hourly, ask for an estimate of total time.
- Service call fee: \$85-\$150 just to show up and diagnose. Some plumbers apply this to the repair cost; some don't. Ask upfront.
- Small leak repair (exposed pipe): \$150-\$350
- Leak detection (specialized equipment to locate hidden leaks): \$175-\$500. Complex cases (slab, behind walls) can run \$1,000+.
- Slab leak repair: \$500-\$3,000+, depending on whether the plumber can access the pipe or needs to reroute it.

Questions to Ask Before You Hire

1. "Is this a flat rate or hourly?"
2. "What's included in the service call? Does the diagnosis fee apply to the repair?"
3. "Can you give me a written estimate before you start work?"
4. "Do you carry liability insurance?"
5. "What's your license number?" (Verify via your state contractor licensing board)

Getting Multiple Quotes

For anything over \$500 estimated repair cost, get three quotes. Use: - Angi (formerly Angie's List) - HomeAdvisor - Nextdoor (neighbor recommendations are often the most reliable)

When you get a quote, make sure each plumber is looking at the same scope of work. Describe the problem the same way to each one. The lowest bid may be cutting corners; the highest may be padding the estimate. Look for the middle, and look at reviews.

What Affects Your Cost

- Time of day/night: Emergency calls (nights, weekends) typically cost 1.5x-2x the normal rate.
- Location: Urban areas are more expensive than rural. Some plumbers charge for travel time.
- Age of home: Older homes with outdated plumbing take longer to work on.
- Accessibility: Crawlspace, tight installs, and concealed work add time and cost.

Action Step: Before you call anyone, use the Leak Severity Calculator from Chapter 3 to determine your zone. If you're in the Green zone, decide if you're actually going to DIY or if you'd rather have a pro handle it. If you're in Yellow or Red, you know roughly what you're looking at cost-wise before you call.

Chapter 6: Finding a Reliable Plumber

Not all plumbers are equal. Here is how to hire someone who will do the job right at a fair price — and avoid the ones who won't.

Check the License

Every state has a contractor licensing board. Ask for the plumber's license number and verify it. A licensed plumber has completed required training and exams, carries insurance, and is subject to consumer protection rules. Unlicensed plumbers may be cheaper, but they also may not carry insurance — which means if they damage your home, you're unprotected.

Ask for References

Any plumber should be able to give you the names of recent customers. Call one or two. Ask: Did they show up on time? Did they do what they said they'd do? Was the final cost close to the estimate? Would you hire them again?

Get It in Writing

A written estimate is not optional — it's protection for both of you. The estimate should include: - Description of the problem - Scope of work (what's included and what's not) - Cost breakdown (labor, materials, permit fees if applicable) - Timeline for completion

If a plumber refuses to give you a written estimate, don't hire them.

Understand Payment Terms

Standard practice: you pay no more than 10-20% upfront, and only for materials — not labor. The balance is due when the work is complete and you're satisfied. If a plumber asks for full payment upfront, that's a red flag.

Red Flags

- Cash-only payment
- No license or insurance
- Can't provide references or written estimate
- High-pressure sales tactics ("This needs to be done today or your house will flood")
- Quote that seems way too low (they'll find ways to add charges later)
- Solicits door-to-door or shows up after a storm with "leftover materials"

The One-Bid Trap

Never accept the first quote you get for a significant plumbing repair. You don't know if it's fair until you've compared it to at least one other estimate. The one-bid trap is how homeowners end up paying double what they should have.

Action Step: Bookmark your state contractor licensing board website. When you need a plumber, you'll know exactly where to verify the license. Write down the name of one plumber who comes recommended by a neighbor or has consistently good reviews. Have their number saved before you need it.

Part 3: The Action Sequence

What to do based on what you found

Chapter 7: If You Can DIY — The Fix Sequence

If your Leak Severity Calculator put you in the Green Zone and you've decided to do the repair yourself, follow this sequence. Don't skip steps.

Step 1: Shut Off the Water

Turn off the supply valve at the affected fixture. If there isn't one, or if you're not sure, shut off the main water. You can't safely work on a pipe that's under pressure.

Step 2: Drain the Line

Open the lowest faucet in the house (usually a basement or ground-floor laundry sink). This releases any pressure in the line and lets water drain out of the section you're working on.

Step 3: Assess the Situation

Before you take anything apart, look at what you're dealing with. Take a photo. Look for the source of the leak and trace it. Identify the component that's failed.

Step 4: Get the Right Part

Bring the failed component to the hardware store and match it exactly. Don't guess — bring the part. Hardware store staff can help you find the right replacement if they can see what you're replacing.

Step 5: Make the Repair

Follow the repair-specific instructions for your situation (washer replacement, flapper, cartridge, etc.). Work slowly. Tighten connections hand-tight first, then a quarter-turn with a wrench. Do not over-tighten — this is how you crack fittings or strip threads.

Step 6: Test Before You Call It Done

Turn the water back on slowly. Watch the repair site closely. Check for drips at every connection. Let the water run for two minutes. Check beneath the sink as well. If there's any seepage, shut off and correct.

Step 7: Clean Up

Wipe down the area under the sink. Put a bowl or tray under the repair site for the first 24 hours in case there's a small seep you missed. Monitor it.

The Stop Signal

If you open a fitting and the threads look corroded, pitted, or damaged — or if you tighten a connection and it still weeps — stop. Call a plumber. You're at the edge of what you can do safely.

Action Step: If you have a Green Zone repair you want to attempt, gather your tools this week: adjustable wrenches (two), plumber's tape, a flashlight, and a small mirror for looking at things from awkward angles. Put them in a zip-top bag and keep them under the sink. When you need them, you'll have them.

Chapter 8: If You Need a Pro — The Call Sequence

You're in the Yellow or Red Zone. Here's how to make the call work for you.

Before You Call

Prepare the following information:

- What type of leak you have (use the classification from Chapter 1)
- Where exactly it is (under sink, behind wall, etc.)
- Photos of the leak and surrounding area
- Whether you've already shut off water
- How long the leak has been present
- Any visible damage to walls, floors, or ceilings
- Any relevant history (this has happened before, it started after a specific event)

This information allows the plumber to understand the scope before they arrive, bring the right equipment, and give you a more accurate estimate.

On the Call

- Describe the problem clearly and concisely
- Mention urgency if applicable (active pressure leak, water damage spreading)
- Ask about service call fees and whether they apply to the repair
- Give them the information you prepared

When They Arrive

A good plumber will: - Inspect the area thoroughly before quoting - Explain what they found and why - Give you a written estimate before starting work - Show you the failed component if you ask

If someone shows up and immediately starts working without explaining the problem or giving you a quote, ask them to stop. You need information before work begins.

After the Repair

- Test everything before they leave (run water, check connections, verify shut-offs work)
- Get an invoice with a full description of work performed
- Ask about warranty on parts and labor
- Keep the invoice for your records

Chapter 9: Protecting Your Home While You Wait

Sometimes you identify a leak on a Friday night and can't get a plumber until Monday. Here's how to contain it without making it worse.

What You Can Do

- Place buckets under active drips. Empty as needed.
- Lay towels around the area to absorb overflow.
- If a ceiling is bulging from water pressure above, poke a small hole with a screwdriver and put a bucket under it. A controlled drip is better than a ceiling collapse.
- For wall leaks, do not cut into the wall yourself. This can make things worse and may interfere with professional repair.

What You Cannot Do as a Permanent Fix

- Epoxy or tape is not a permanent solution for pressure leaks. If you have a pressure leak, shut off your water and call a pro. Tape and epoxy are for temporary containment only.
- Do not ignore a leak "to see if it gets worse." That's how you get mold and structural damage.
- Do not try to patch a slab leak yourself.

Document Everything

Take photos of the leak, the water damage, the affected areas. Note the date and time. If you file an insurance claim, documentation matters. Even if you don't file a claim, photos help the plumber understand the history of the problem when they arrive.

The 48-Hour Rule

Any leak left unaddressed for more than 48 hours has the potential to develop mold, damage structural members, or void your homeowner's insurance coverage for the event. If you've been ignoring a leak for more than two days, treat it as urgent regardless of what the calculator said.

Action Step: If you have a Yellow Zone leak you're waiting to get repaired, check on it twice a day. Morning and evening. Note any change in the drip rate, the size of the wet area, or any new damage. If it worsens, move to Red Zone protocol and call a pro sooner.

Part 4: Prevention and Maintenance

Keep this from happening again

Chapter 10: The Annual Plumbing Audit

Once a year, walk through your home's plumbing system with this checklist. It's about 30 minutes and can catch problems before they become emergencies.

Check 1: Water Meter

Turn off every water source in your house — all faucets, appliances, irrigation. Go outside and look at your water meter. If the dial is still moving, you have a leak somewhere in your home. This doesn't tell you where; it only tells you there is one. Investigate.

Check 2: Supply Lines Under Every Sink

Open every cabinet under every sink. Look at the supply lines (the two hoses going to the faucet and the shut-off valve). Look for: - Dampness or corrosion on the connectors - Rust or mineral buildup - Any visible kinks or wear If you're within 10-15 years of when the lines were installed, consider replacing them preventively. Braided stainless steel lines are \$10-\$20 each and take 10 minutes to swap.

Check 3: Water Heater

- Age: Find the manufacture date on the tank (serial number format — first two digits are usually the year). If it's more than 10 years old, start budgeting for replacement.
- Anode rod: This is a sacrificial component that prevents the tank from corroding. It should be checked and replaced every 3-5 years. If you've never had it checked and your heater is more than 5 years old, call a plumber to inspect and replace it.
- Sediment: If you have hard water, sediment builds up in the tank and reduces efficiency. A plumber can flush the tank.

Check 4: Main Shut-Off Valve

Go to your main shut-off. Turn it off and back on. It should operate smoothly. If it's stiff, grinding, or doesn't fully close, have it serviced or replaced. A seized shut-off valve is a liability in an emergency.

Check 5: Toilet Tank Components

Remove the tank lid and look inside: - Flapper: Is it warped, cracked, or has a buildup of mineral deposits? Replace every 5-7 years. - Fill valve: Does it shut off cleanly, or does it keep running? A running toilet can waste 200 gallons of water per day. - Overflow tube: Is water going into it? The fill valve may need adjustment if the water level is too high.

Check 6: Outdoor Spigots and Irrigation

Check outdoor spigots for leaks when you turn them on. Look at the connections for dampness. Winterize outdoor lines if you live in a climate with freezing temperatures — a frozen pipe that bursts can cause thousands in damage. Disconnect hoses from spigots before winter.

Check 7: Water Pressure

Buy a \$10 pressure gauge from any hardware store. Attach it to an outdoor spigot or laundry faucet. Normal range: 40-80 psi. If it's over 80, install a pressure reducer (or call a plumber to do it). High pressure stresses your entire plumbing system and increases leak risk.

Check 8: Visible Pipe Condition

Walk through your basement or crawl space. Look at all visible pipes. Look for: - Green or white mineral buildup at joints - Rust or corrosion - Dampness at joints - Any discoloration on pipes (sign of a past or active slow leak)

Action Step: Schedule this audit once a year — perhaps when you change your clocks (spring forward / fall back is a good trigger). Keep this checklist in a folder so you can reference it and mark what you found.

Chapter 11: What Breaks First

Every component in your plumbing system has a lifespan. Knowing the numbers lets you replace things on your terms, before they fail on theirs.

Supply Lines (Braided Stainless Steel) Lifespan: 10-15 years. Replace preventively if you see any surface corrosion or if they're older than 10 years. They're \$10-\$20 each.

Faucet Cartridges Lifespan: 8-12 years, depending on water quality. A worn cartridge causes a persistent drip that washer replacement won't fix. Replacement cartridges are \$15-\$30.

Water Heater Tank Lifespan: 8-12 years (tank style). Tankless units can last 20+ years. If your tank heater is more than 10 years old and you're seeing rusty water, insufficient hot water, or sediment noise, start planning for replacement. Don't wait for it to fail — a failed water heater can release 50+ gallons of water in a rupture.

Toilet Flapper Lifespan: 5-7 years. Replace proactively every 5 years. It costs \$5 and takes 10 minutes. The alternative is a running toilet that wastes hundreds of dollars in water per year.

Gate Valves (Main Shut-Off) Lifespan: 10-20 years, but they can seize if not operated. If your main shut-off is more than 15 years old and you've never operated it, try it once a year. If it doesn't turn smoothly, have it replaced. The cost (a few hundred dollars for a plumber to replace it in a planned way) is nothing compared to the cost of not being able to shut off your water in an emergency.

Washing Machine Supply Lines Lifespan: 5-10 years. Replace with braided lines (not rubber). Rubber supply lines are a leading cause of catastrophic home water damage. Replace every 5 years as a matter of course.

The Proactive Replacement Signal

The rule: if a component is past its expected lifespan AND showing any signs of wear (corrosion, rust, cracking, or change in performance), budget for replacement now. Proactive replacement is almost always less expensive than emergency service — both in dollars and in damage control.

Conclusion: What You've Built

If you've made it here, you now have something most homeowners don't: a framework for thinking about plumbing leaks. Not a collection of tips that will evaporate when you're standing in water at midnight, but a system.

Let's recap what you've learned:

1. **Leaks are classified by type** (slow seep, active drip, pressure leak, hidden leak, slab leak), and each has different urgency and repair paths.
2. **You know where your shut-off valves are and how to use them.** If a pressure leak ever happens, you can act immediately instead of standing in water hoping someone will help.
3. **You can calculate your leak's severity** using the 7-point rubric, which tells you whether to DIY, schedule a pro, or call a pro now.

4. **You know what belongs in the DIY range** (washers, flappers, supply lines, cartridge replacements) and what doesn't (anything with pressure, anything inside walls, anything with gas).
5. **You know how to get a fair price from a plumber** by asking the right questions, comparing quotes, and verifying licenses.
6. **You have an annual maintenance checklist** that keeps your plumbing system healthy before problems emerge.
7. **You know the lifespans of your plumbing components** and can plan replacements instead of emergency-reacting.

Here's the truth: plumbing is not actually that complicated. It just feels intimidating if you've never been shown the map. Now you have the map.

The goal isn't to fix everything yourself. The goal is to know enough to make the right call — whether that's to DIY or to dial.

Your Next Steps

This guide gives you the framework. The companion tools give you the action reference.

Tool 1: Leak Severity Calculator A print-ready quick-reference of the 7-point rubric. Cut it out, laminate it, and keep it near your main shut-off valve. When you need it, you'll have it.

Tool 2: Plumber Call Preparation Sheet A single-page document with the questions to ask, information to have ready, and the cost estimation framework from Chapter 5. Pull it up on your phone before you make the call.

[Get the complete Plumbing Leak Decision Guide with both bonus tools — available in your Lemon Squeezy library]

Key Takeaways

- Classify your leak before you decide anything. The type determines the urgency and repair path.
- Shut off your water at the first sign of a pressure leak. Never try to repair a pressurized pipe.

- Use the 7-point Leak Severity Calculator to determine whether you're in the Green, Yellow, or Red zone — and follow the action recommendation.
 - DIY range: washers, flappers, supply lines, cartridges. Everything else: call a pro.
 - Get three quotes for any repair over \$500. Verify licenses and get written estimates.
 - Annual maintenance catches problems early. The audit checklist takes 30 minutes once a year.
 - Know your component lifespans. Proactive replacement is always cheaper than emergency replacement.
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You don't need to be a plumber. You just need to know enough to make the right call.